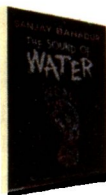


Hauled Over the Coals

This first novel excavates the hidden brutality of the mining fields

| By Bunny Suraiya |



THE SOUND OF WATER
by SANJAY BAHADUR
Indialink/Roli
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 168

My cousin was married to the manager of a coal mine in Bihar, who quit his job as soon as the mines got nationalised. When I asked why, his reply was simple: 'I don't trust the safety standards in mines run by the government'.

Many mine disasters since have proved his fears to be well-founded, but even minds inured to the repeated horrors of headlines from collieries in Kessurgarh, Gaslitand and most notably, Chasnala where 375 miners drowned, will find Sanjay Bahadur's book a riveting—and appalling—indictment of India's mine management beneath the malevolent gaze of the sarkar.

The Sound of Water, a first novel by a civil servant, is a long-overdue expose on the criminal nexus forged by the police, politicians, bureaucrats, union leaders and mine managers—all of them a pack of self-serving, buck-passing and cynically exploitative scoundrels.

In the resounding silence of a coal mine, often as deep as a kilometre beneath the surface of the earth, "the sound that (spells) doom for a miner" is the sound of water. Raimoti, a man old before his time, strains to hear the faint trickle that will alert him to the presence of what he calls "the Beast" which he knows will devour him one day.

Experience has taught him that the tunnel in which he works is far too close to the walls of a dammed-up lake, and that each time his pick-axe gouges out yet another tonne of coal, he gets that much closer to death.

He tries to warn the supervisor but is ignored. He pleads to speak with the manager, but the

manager, Bibhash Mukherjee, has his own problems. He hates his posting, longs for the city, finds solace in whisky and pornographic magazines, and is desperately trying to get the attention of his own boss, Pandeyji, who loses no opportunity to humiliate him. Mukherjee has no time for the expendable dregs of humanity who slave underground to pay his salary.

Pandeyji, a hypocrite, a coward and a liar, in turn toadies up to bureaucrats like Shri Atul Karna who represent the ministry and make fleeting visits to the mine, expecting—and getting—liquor, sumptuous meals and air-conditioned accommodation before heading back to their desks to submit formulaic reports to their political masters who file and forget about them.

Bahadur, a civil servant himself, understands

the process only too well, and his anger with the system comes through clearly: "the ultimate 'ownership' of a public-sector company is vested in the 'people', but... every simple worker understands that this really means some minister is the lord and master. In a democracy the people's representative is more of a king than Caesar."

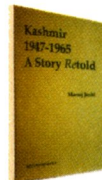
The dehumanising effect of the system percolates down into the lives of the miners themselves; in the aftermath of tragedy, Raimoti's brother and sister-in-law eagerly await confirmation of his death in order to claim the compensation due to his next of kin, ignoring the fact that his daughters have a better claim. As Dolly, the lubricious sister-in-law puts it to her husband, "don't let sentiments and foolish ethics get involved..."

That statement, in all its pragmatic cynicism, could well sum up the attitude of the government and its minions to the toiling masses they claim to serve.

This book should be made required reading for every bureaucrat, politician and schoolchild in this country.

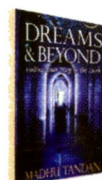


SAURABH SINGH



KASHMIR 1947-1965: A STORY RETOLD
by MANOJ JOSHI
India Research Press
Price: \$39.95
Pages: 252

Focuses on the background of the state's accession to India and the subsequent dispute at the UN.



DREAMS & BEYOND
by MADHUL TANDAN
Hay House India
Price: Rs 395
Pages: 563

By exploring the multiplicity of the dreaming experience, the book shows that the meaning of a dream can be unlocked with many different keys.



BAHUDHA AND THE POST 9/11 WORLD
by BALMIKI PRASAD SINGH
Oxford
Price: Rs 745
Pages: 370

Propounds the concept of *Bahudha*, a dialogue of harmony, in the age of fundamentalism and terrorism.